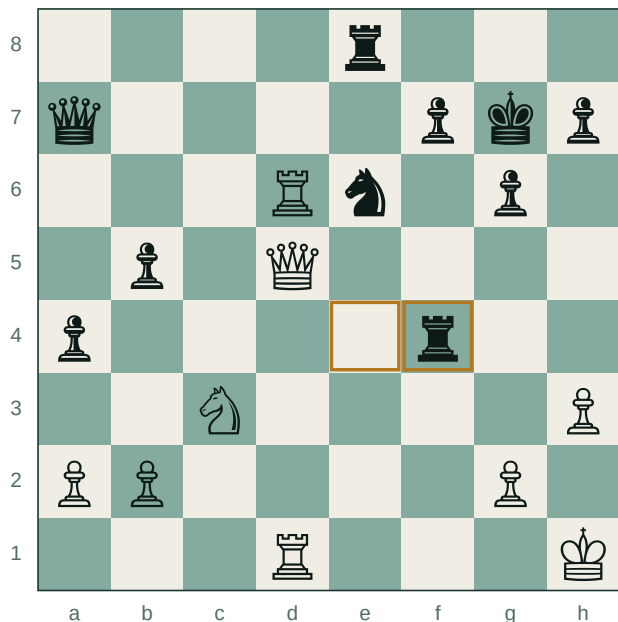


Capture the defender: White, move 34

Capture the defender

White to move



Previous move: 33...Rxf4. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

34. Qe5+ Kh6 35. Rxe6 Rxe6 36. Qxf4+

34.Qe5+ Check restricts Black to 5 legal replies here. From e5 it attacks king on g7, rook on f4 and knight on e6. Recorded reply: **34...Kh6**.

35.Rxe6 The rook captures the knight on e6. Recorded reply: **35...Rxe6**.

36.Qxf4+ Check restricts Black to 3 legal replies here. The move also takes the rook on f4.

At the end, nominal material is White 21 / Black 19 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, White's balance changes by +3. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does White's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +3: the balance goes from -1 to +2. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

Do not assume a defender is unique. Another piece may take over its job, or the opponent may decline to recapture.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

Removing a key defender can transform a protected square into a winning entry. The defender's function explains why the first capture matters.

HOW TO LOOK

Identify the protected target, capture its essential defender, and calculate the follow-up after each plausible recapture.

The defending king is on g7. Geometrically undefended: rook on e8 and queen on a7. Check for tactical protection.